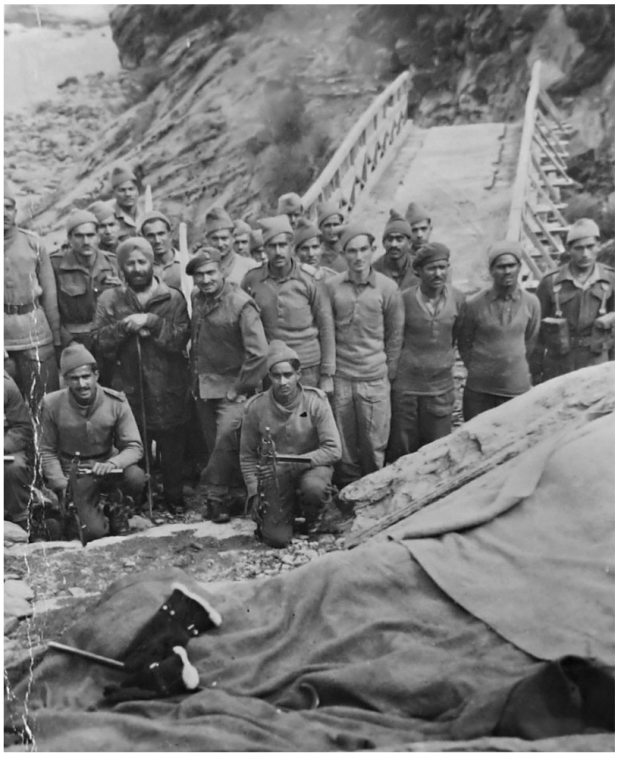
also employed increasing numbers of regular units and formations in the conflict.



Troops of 3 GARH RIF with Brigadier Bikram Singh after the battle of Tithwal. In May 1948, 163 Infantry Brigade was tasked with advancing along the Kupwara–Handwara axis and crossing Nastachun Pass to capture Tithwal valley. The operation commenced on 18 May and by the morning of 23 May, Tithwal had been captured. Over the next six months, the Pakistan Army made numerous attempts to evict the Indian troops but failed. One of the Indian units that participated in the battle of Tithwal, 3 GARH RIF gained the distinction of becoming one of the most decorated battalions of the Indian Army in any one operation after independence, with 20 gallantry awards and 19 mentions in despatches. It was also given the battle honour 'Tithwal'. (Courtesy Sandeep Kang)

The Indian Army launched an offensive in March–April 1948 with 19 (Independent) Infantry Brigade and 50 (Independent) Parachute Brigade advancing along the Naushera–Rajouri axis. They recaptured Jhangar and then occupied Rajouri, but failed to lift the siege of Poonch even as the RIAF continued to maintain the garrison from the air. With the increase in brigades deployed in the state, and to better coordinate their operations, in early May 1948 Indian Army HQ formed a temporary headquarters, the